

A HANDBOOK

The Tao *of* DHH

On writing software, keeping a company small, owning your machines, and refusing the second-best things first.

PROGRAMMING · WORK · MONEY · SPEED · FAMILY

*Nobody knows anything.
Nobody can see six months ahead.
Learn the thing anyway.*

THE FIRST RULE

Contents

BOOK ONE · THE WAY IN

- 1 The Three Failures · *on beginners, and what a tool owes them*
- 2 The Lost Ease · *ergonomics, and who took them*
- 3 The Dark Ages · *churn, build pipelines, and the bridge*

BOOK TWO · BEAUTY

- 4 Line Noise · *what to remove and what to keep long*
- 5 Trust · *a language is a theory of people*
- 6 Keywords of Your Own · *metaprogramming, types, sharp knives*
- 7 On Scale · *latency, luxury, and human cores*

BOOK THREE · THE DOCTRINE

- 8 Write Down the Fence · *why a community records its values*
- 9 The Finished Toy · *convention, omakase, the monolith*

BOOK FOUR · THE MACHINE

- 10 Fingers · *what you lose when you stop typing*
- 11 The Veneer · *vibe coding, editors, and empty calories*
- 12 The Horse · *gratitude, and the flattening curve*

BOOK FIVE · THE COMPANY

- 13 Against Managers · *the door you can close*
- 14 Two People, One Feature · *small teams, and why they are not a waypoint*
- 15 Other People's Money · *the playbook you avoid by refusing the check*
- 16 Not Wearing It Out · *partnership, meetings, and forty hours*

BOOK SIX · THE METAL

- 17 The Bill · *leaving the cloud*
- 18 Owning the Thing · *racks, home labs, and the original network*

BOOK SEVEN · KINGDOMS AND GIFTS

- 19 Toll Booths · *permission, Apple, and saying no*
- 20 Good Intentions · *regulation, monopoly, and the monument*
- 21 The Gift Exchange · *open source and the mad king*

BOOK EIGHT · THE LIFE

- 22 Mojito Island · *flow, retirement, and the top five percent*
- 23 The Chair and the Bloodline · *family, and the scale that goes to a hundred*
- 24 The Edge of Adhesion · *speed, danger, and the guaranteed flow*
- 25 The Desk · *tools worth the hours you put into them*
- 26 Second-Best Things · *money, empty calendars, and hope*

BOOK ONE

The Way In

*Three failures, one blinking tag, and a standard of ease the industry
spent twenty years mislaying.*

CHAPTER 1

The Three Failures

On beginners, and what a tool owes them

1

Wanting a thing badly is not the same as understanding it, and no amount of wanting substitutes for a good first hour.

A beginner who receives only error messages is right to leave.
The fault belongs to whatever issued the errors.

2

You can belong to a scene long before you can contribute to it, and the wanting will teach you more than a course.

Proximity to competence is contagious, and the sting of not having it yet is fuel.

3

The first success must be small, immediate, visible, and unpermitted.

One moment of the machine rewarding you outweighs years of it scolding you. Every argument about ergonomics in this book descends from that.

7

4

*If it smells like programming, it counts as a
door.*

Purity about what qualifies as real work mostly serves the
people already inside.

5

Learn on something you actually want to exist.

Abstract exercises don't carry anyone through the frustrating
middle; a program you want badly enough drags your
learning behind it.

CHAPTER 2

The Lost Ease

Ergonomics, and who took them

6

The high-water mark of web ergonomics was a script, an upload, and a reload.

Treat it as a bar rather than a memory. Anything that makes shipping harder owes you an account of what the difficulty bought.

7

The web is still forms writing rows to a database. Make peace with it.

Most of the elaborate machinery in this trade is compensation for the discomfort of that admission.

8

Complexity is sold to you. Stop buying from the merchants.

Developers handed away their own comfort to vendors who profited from the handing.

9

Faster machines should have bought simpler work. If they didn't, somebody spent the dividend.

Hardware improved by orders of magnitude while the daily experience of shipping got heavier. That gap is somebody's revenue.

10

Nostalgia is its own trap. Plenty of it was bad.

The aim is to fold twenty years of real advances into something that still feels immediate. Both halves are required.

11

Working with other people doesn't oblige you to abandon the simple way. It obliges you to teach one thing.

Add the minimum tool the second person needs, then get back to work. Don't import an entire methodology with them.

11

CHAPTER 3

The Dark Ages

Churn, build pipelines, and the bridge

12

*Judge a language by what it does well, not by the
trick you can make it do badly.*

Most famous language complaints describe a behaviour
nobody was obliged to invoke.

13

*If you put a project down for five minutes and it
no longer builds, the environment is sick. You
are fine.*

Blaming yourself for the instability of your tools is how the
instability survives.

14

*Churn is not progress. A community that
rewrites itself every quarter accumulates no
wisdom.*

Skills that expire in ninety days aren't skills, they're rent.

15

Complexity follows the organisation chart. A company that slices one job into fifteen will ship tools shaped like fifteen jobs.

Adopt those tools and you inherit a structure you never hired for.

16

Some complexity was a bridge. Thank it, cross it, then get off it.

A workaround that dragged the platform forward has no claim on you once the platform arrives.

17

Splitting front end from back end divided a problem that wanted one head holding it.

Divide the work and you get camps, and camps produce the protocols that camps need.

18

Every page ever made still renders. That miracle is why a new browser is an Apollo programme.

The cost of entry is why almost nobody tries, and why a single dominant engine is a risk worth paying to avoid.

19

Hold the gift and the surveillance in the same hand.

You don't resolve the tension by pretending one half away.
Some things that fund what you dislike also protect what you
need.

BOOK TWO

Beauty

That code could be beautiful, and that beauty could outrank other goals, is not obvious. It has to be shown.

CHAPTER 4

Line Noise

What to remove, and what to keep long

20

*Gratitude for a tool and love of a tool are
different things, and only one of them makes
you a programmer.*

Identity arrives with the medium you would choose freely,
not the one you happened to be handed.

21

*Answer a stranger's question well. Careers start
there.*

The internet's oldest gift is that useful help can arrive
without introduction, credential, or permission.

22

*Build the thing that fixes the mess you keep
making. One page. No seminar.*

If it needs a training session before anyone can use it, it isn't
finished.

23

*Notice which language the clever people reach for
when they explain an idea. That choice is data.*

A notation chosen for explaining is a notation optimised for
the reader, which is the property you were looking for.

24

*Ask who each character in the syntax serves. If it
isn't you, somebody else is being accommodated.*

Punctuation that exists to comfort a parser is a tax the reader
pays on the machine's behalf.

25

*Budget two weeks for the proof of concept. If it
takes a weekend, stop looking.*

The gap between what you expected the work to cost and
what it actually cost is the clearest signal a tool can give you.

26

Line noise is every character the human didn't need.

Name it and you can start removing it. Unnamed, it reads as the normal price of programming.

27

Legacy explains ugliness. It doesn't excuse it.

"It has always been this way" is a history, not a defence, and it should not survive contact with a redesign.

28

Delete what the human doesn't need. Never abbreviate what the human has to read.

Optimise for reading, not for typing. You write a word once and read it a thousand times.

29

*Ambiguity that serves the reader is worth every
hour it costs the interpreter.*

Several ways to say the same thing complicate the parser and
let the line read like a sentence somebody would say aloud.

30

*Compress to the essence, then stop. Past the essence
lies the unreadable.*

The good feeling comes from nothing left to remove. Keep
removing and you get a puzzle nobody can maintain.

CHAPTER 5

Trust

A language is a theory of people

31

*Every language encodes a theory of who
programmers are. Choose the theory you want to
live inside.*

One theory says people must be protected from sharpness.
The other says people have an unlimited capacity to improve.
Each produces the tool it deserves.

32

*The highest compliment a designer can pay you
is to let you write in his book as an equal.*

A system that lets a stranger extend it indistinguishably from
its author is expressing a view about strangers.

33

Efficient markets copy everything except essence.

Pieces get borrowed; coherence doesn't. That's why a good
design can stay uncopied for thirty years.

34

*Ship the first version slightly broken. Nothing
recruits help faster than a problem somebody
knows how to fix.*

Polish alone until nobody can see a way in and you've built a
monument instead of a community.

35

Provide sharp knives.

Cut yourself once in software and the finger grows back
along with the competence. Dull tools injure you slowly
instead, over years.

Keywords of Your Own

Metaprogramming, types, and knowing the scale you work at

36

*The best framework code looks like the language
grew a keyword for your problem.*

Tailor a general language to a narrow domain and people can
read the result aloud without translating it first.

37

*Power without noise is rare. Power with noise is
common.*

Plenty of languages let you extend them. The rare thing is
extending them without charging ceremony for the privilege.

38

*Own your aesthetic limits out loud, then go do
the reading anyway.*

A verdict formed without the experience can stand while the
homework remains owed.

39

*Don't uglify a beautiful thing to buy a comfort
you never needed.*

Safety features have a price in expressiveness. Pay it only if
you were going to use the safety.

40

*A language with excellent autocompletion
develops an appetite for boilerplate. Refuse the
tooling to keep the language honest.*

Make filler free to type and filler multiplies. The friction is
doing work.

41

*Ask whether the object answers, not what it
descends from. Catch the rest with tests.*

Runtime extension is only possible where identity is
behaviour rather than ancestry.

42

You don't take the Pagani to Costco.

Tools excellent at one scale transfer badly to another. In every domain but programming languages, we remember this.

43

Preference is fine. Announcing it as the only path to correct software, against the evidence, is not.

Brains are wired differently. Make the concession, and notice how rarely it comes back.

CHAPTER 7

On Scale

Latency, luxury, and human cores

44

*A million dynamic requests a second, on a
dynamic language, settles the theoretical
objection.*

Once something exists at that size, arguments that it cannot
exist are no longer arguments.

45

The measure of a tool is its dynamic range.

It has to fit the beginner and the giant, and the same person
must be able to travel between them without switching tools.

46

*Design for the snowboard shop, not for the
company it became.*

Everything large started as one person holding the whole
system in one head. Serve that case and the rest follows.

47

*Compare tools at the beginning of the story.
Agility is what buys you the right to a rewrite
later.*

A stack judged only by how it ends at enormous scale is
judged on a stage most projects never reach.

48

*Tools born inside giants carry the giant's shape.
That isn't a flaw; it's a fact to account for.*

Adopt one without noticing and you end up wearing a
stranger's coat.

49

*Unbundle the word scale. Latency is one
question, throughput another, money a third.*

Answer three separate questions with one language choice
and you'll get all three wrong.

50

A luxury language is affordable to nearly everyone who thinks they can't afford it.

Only applications earning almost nothing per request are forced down to the cheap and low-level.

51

The scarce resource is human cores. Do the arithmetic before optimising the other kind.

The main cost of a web application is people understanding and evolving it, and that line item never appears on the invoice.

52

The excitement about AI is the old excitement about productivity, arriving again.

One person doing the work of several was the promise of every good tool. The moment is less of a rupture than it looks.

BOOK THREE

The Doctrine

Values got written down in 2012 because a community that doesn't record what it believes eventually forgets why the fence was there.

CHAPTER 8

Write Down the Fence

Why a community records its values

53

*Record the values or watch strangers pull up a
fence nobody remembers building.*

Institutions fall apart quietly: enough new arrivals with their
own ideas, no stated principle to decide against, and the thing
starts flailing.

54

*Programmer happiness comes first, and it has to
cost something real.*

If nothing is ever traded away for it, it isn't first. Expect to
give up some runtime, some performance, some tidiness in
the parser.

55

Let people quit the way they expect to quit.

When two guesses are equally natural, support both.
Correcting the user is not the same as serving them.

*The principle of least surprise has no single
answer, which is why you provide two.*

One blessed way per task means deciding whose instinct
wins. Affordances let you stop deciding.

CHAPTER 9

The Finished Toy

Convention, omakase, and the system one person can hold

57

*Convention over configuration: nobody cares
what you name the foreign key, so stop asking.*

Settle the consequenceless questions once, depend on the
answer, and you reach the part that matters sooner.

58

*Hand people a finished toy, not a box of bricks
and a photograph of a spaceship.*

Assembly is the pleasure programmers reach for by reflex.
Redirect that instinct higher up the stack.

59

*Let a chef choose the menu. Infinite choice is not
generosity; it's an abdication.*

Where nobody curates, no two teams share a stack for long,
and a whole community retains no wisdom.

60

*No single paradigm. Take the best of each and
remix.*

The value of a good framework is rarely novelty. It's the
coherence of the combination.

61

*The first rule of distributed programming: don't
distribute your programming.*

Turning method calls into network calls multiplies every
failure mode. Do it only when a single head genuinely can't
hold the system.

62

*Compress the system until it fits in one person's
head, then defend that boundary.*

Somewhere past half a million lines nobody can hold it, and
only there does splitting become honest rather than
fashionable.

63

Accept the database instead of hiding from it.

Abstractions that pretend persistence isn't happening spend
their lives contorting to translate back.

64

A soft ramp that never ends.

Make the first step trivial and treat it as an invitation, never as
permission to stay incompetent. Productive in days; well-
rounded in years.

65

*Progress over stability is the principle most likely
to age badly.*

Churn looks like the price of staying current until you watch
a community treat instability as a virtue.

66

Almost nothing moves as fast as it feels. Three shifts in a career, and everything else was increments.

Knowing how glacial most technology actually is protects you from being stampeded by each new arrival.

67

Changing your mind in public is cheap. Changing it back after testing is the valuable move.

The best-held opinions are the ones abandoned, tried the other way, and returned to with better reasons.

BOOK FOUR

The Machine

Use it all day. Don't let it drive. Both halves matter, and the reasoning behind each is worth having.

CHAPTER 10

Fingers

What you lose when you stop typing

68

*When you collaborate with a machine, you
want the highest-bandwidth language
available.*

Whoever typed it, both parties have to read it fast. Density
matters more as code arrives pre-written, not less.

69

Keep it in a separate window.

A tool beside the work preserves your immediacy with the
material. A tool inside the work takes the material away.

70

*You learn with your fingers. Nobody ever
learned guitar from videos.*

Using an expression is not learning it. The repetitions are
what convert watching into skill.

71

*Half a per cent smarter a day compounds. So
does half a per cent dumber.*

The same assistant, on the same project, in the same week,
can move you either way. The difference is who does the
typing.

72

*It's the pair programmer an introvert can
tolerate.*

The useful half of pairing without the social cost that made
the practice unsustainable.

73

Being a beginner is fun again.

The unfamiliar domain stops being a wall. Expect the
opposite where you're already expert: impressed by the first
answer, drumming your fingers by the third.

74

The complaint isn't that it's stupid. It's that it's slow, and that it promotes you out of the work.

Waiting on an agent feels like waiting on a compiler. Losing
your touch feels like a promotion.

75

The joy is in the playing, not in the recording.

A perfect recording of every song exists and millions still
want to play them. The program is the economic output; the
writing is the human one.

CHAPTER 11

The Veneer

Vibe coding, editors, and empty calories

76

If you want to learn, more of your time goes into writing from scratch, not less.

You won't get fit watching fitness videos. Humans don't convert observation into skill, however well machines do.

77

Learning that feels like learning while you generate is empty calories.

The temptation is strongest where you know least, which is exactly where the retention matters most.

78

If anyone can generate it, you aren't a programmer. That may turn out to be wonderful.

Tools that let non-programmers build their own ideas are a good outcome. They just don't confer the craft.

79

*Editors have to be doers. There is no great editor
who cannot write.*

You can't say what's wrong with a solution you couldn't have
produced. The right to edit is earned by doing.

80

*The actual promise was that clumsy words
would be enough.*

A future of specialists who know how to tickle the model just
right is a worse future than one where anybody's messy
description works.

81

Generated systems fail early, not late.

A convincing surface with holes underneath. The tell is the
whack-a-mole: fix one thing, break five.

CHAPTER 12

The Horse

Gratitude, and the flattening curve

82

*Manual programming may become a horse.
Millions still ride.*

A skill can lose its economic peak and keep every bit of its
worth to the person practising it.

83

*If what you're good at stops being valued,
answer with gratitude rather than grievance.*

Decades in which the work you loved most was also well paid
is a run of luck, not an entitlement.

84

*Tapping approve all day is productive for a
moment and marketable for none.*

If anyone can hold the job, it isn't a job.

85

*Nobody knows anything. Do not draw the line
straight through the early dots.*

Some curves keep climbing and some flatten within a decade,
and from inside the excitement they look identical.

86

*A society can lose a competence it still needs,
because it was busy chasing the future.*

The systems you consider obsolete tend to outlive the people
who understand them.

87

*Position yourself so that you're content with
every outcome.*

Set the measure of success before you start, and make every
branch acceptable. Then nothing that happens can wreck
you.

BOOK FIVE

The Company

*Fifty people, no engineering managers, a default team of two, and
twenty-five years of not wearing each other out.*

CHAPTER 13

Against Managers

The door you can close

88

Run the experiment before you trust the conviction. Then run it again on yourself.

An instinct that survives a fair test comes back as evidence,
which is a stronger thing to hold.

89

Feedback about your work has to come from somebody better at it than you.

Anyone can tell you how you show up. Only a stronger practitioner can tell you what's wrong with what you made.

90

People promoted out of the craft lose the feel for it faster than anyone expects.

What replaces it is a talent for checking status, which is not what the person doing the work needs.

91

The great work of this industry came out of tiny teams with nobody managing them.

Consistent enough across decades to be cause rather than coincidence.

92

You don't get good until you have a door you can close for six hours.

Every organisational preference worth holding descends from protecting that condition for other people.

93

Treat management as a service you call for seven hours, then take back down to zero.

A role that exists permanently will find work to justify itself.
Roles you summon can't.

*Being quirky about your own operations is a
luxury with a bill attached.*

Falling in love with your own unusual arrangement is how a
small oversight compounds for a decade.

Two People, One Feature

Small teams, and why they are not a waypoint

95

The default team is two: one programmer, one designer, one feature.

At that size you don't need methodology, layers, or a process for reaching agreement. You make the thing and look at it.

96

Don't map eighteen months of steps. You'll know far more one step in.

Humans are poor at imagining a distant path and good at putting one foot down, then the next.

97

One person and a few hundred focused hours is a serious industrial quantity.

The unit of creation is smaller than almost every plan assumes.

98

Small is not a stepping stone.

The enjoyment of building is inseparable from building with
a handful of people. Scale offers a different reward, not a
better one.

99

*A thousand people will build the software a
thousand people build.*

Output takes the shape of the organisation, so a giant cannot
produce your product even by trying.

CHAPTER 15

Other People's Money

The playbook you avoid by refusing the check

100

Don't take other people's money.

Whoever hands it over reasonably wants the largest return, and they get none of the daily satisfaction of the work. Their satisfaction has to come from the number.

101

*The check comes with a playbook, and the
playbook ends with a thousand people.*

Find fit, abandon the small customers, chase whales with a sales force. It works often enough to be standard, and it builds a company you'd hate.

102

*A little off the table is a vaccine against the big
check.*

Enough personal security to say no is worth more than growth capital you didn't need.

103

*Conviction handed to you is a gift, and it's easy
to notice its value only in hindsight.*

Somebody betting on you before the evidence exists changes
what you're willing to attempt.

104

*Conviction against the odds is the skill worth
stealing from people richer than you.*

If somebody held their nerve at enormous scale against
universal doubt, your own self-doubt at a small scale looks
unserious.

105

*Value creates its opposite. Only mediocrity
escapes the haters.*

If many people love what you make, an equal population
must dislike it. The only exit is being uninteresting.

Not Wearing It Out

Partnership, meetings, and forty hours

106

Fight about the idea, never about the person.

"You're an idiot for looking at it that way" survives twenty years. "You're an idiot" doesn't.

107

*Found a company with somebody whose
competence doesn't overlap yours.*

Then half the arguments end early, because the decision belongs to somebody you trust.

108

Disagree and commit.

You get to be wrong out loud, and then you get to move.

109

There is a finite amount of exchange in any relationship. Spend it slowly.

Contact that could have lasted decades can be exhausted in a few years of proximity.

110

Meetings are toxic, and the executive layer generates them because telling people things is the job.

Stay part of the implementation and you slow your own horse. Live purely in ideas and every notion becomes somebody else's week.

111

There is too much bouncing and not enough scoring.

Collaboration is treated as an unmixed good. Ideas need a few exchanges and then a long stretch of somebody alone, building.

112

*Loneliness is real, and work is the wrong place to
solve it.*

Humans need humans. You just don't need forty hours a
week of them at the office.

113

*Forty hours is plenty, and most people squander
it.*

The work happens in uninterrupted blocks of two to five
hours; the difficulty is getting a block whole.

114

*Refuse the false trade. Money or family or
health, pick one, is a sales pitch.*

A sprint is fine. A sprint that runs a decade gets paid for
whether or not the company works, and most of the time it
doesn't.

115

*Winner-takes-all is a story somebody sold you.
Most fields have room for many winners.*

Not dominating a category is only a failure if somebody else's
scoreboard is the one you're using.

116

Hire on the work product, not the pedigree.

Résumés mislead in both directions often enough that only
the artifact is worth trusting.

117

*The ability to evaluate work directly is a
superpower, and it can't be delegated.*

It's what lets you bet on somebody with no track record and
let go of somebody with an impressive one.

118

*Great missions attract talent. They don't have to
hunt for it.*

Audacity and clarity do the recruiting, which is why the most
ambitious goals get the best people cheapest.

119

*Vision needs to be anchored in knowing enough,
or it's just demanding speed.*

Anyone can tell engineers to go faster. The rare thing is
arriving with the simplification they didn't see.

BOOK SIX

The Metal

An expense report is a program. Waste in either one is a splinter in the brain.

CHAPTER 17

The Bill

Leaving the cloud

120

*An inefficient business offends the same nerve as
a program full of line noise.*

Opportunity cost is real, and so is money that lands on the
bottom line and gets shared with the people who earned it.

121

*When faster computers stop making things
cheaper, ask who is collecting the difference.*

A bill that grows while the hardware underneath it gets
cheaper every year is somebody's margin, not your
consumption.

122

*Check each promise separately. Usually one of
them was true.*

Bundled pitches survive because nobody audits the parts.
Easier, cheaper and faster rarely arrive together.

123

Large migrations are mostly imagined obstacles.

The headcount you were told you'd need is frequently zero,
and the timeline is frequently months rather than years.

124

*Owning beats renting when you need the thing
for years. This is not a controversial idea
anywhere else.*

We understand it about vehicles and buildings. In computing
an entire industry agreed it had stopped applying.

Owning the Thing

Racks, home labs, and the original network

125

When one region goes down and a third of the internet goes with it, something has been lost.

The network was designed so that losing a city wouldn't silence the rest. We rebuilt it around a handful of nodes that matter enormously.

126

Look inside a modern server. Most people have no idea what they're renting.

A decade of abstraction left programmers with no sense of how much machine sits behind an instance name.

127

Owning your own machines has never been more feasible, and the expertise is not exotic.

Cables, power, boot Linux. That's how the whole internet was built until about a dozen years ago.

128

The garage startup is becoming literal again.

Domestic hardware and domestic connections now exceed
what serious businesses ran on a decade or two ago.

129

*Progress sneaks up on you, and old assumptions
outlive the hardware they were built for.*

Designs calcify around constraints that quietly disappeared,
and nobody revisits them for years.

130

At the frontier, owning matters more, not less.

Renting is a tax you pay for someone else's flexibility, and at
the edge of what's possible you can't afford either the tax or
the wait.

BOOK SEVEN

Kingdoms and Gifts

*Who gets to charge you for permission, who gets to legislate your web,
and what you may and may not take back once you've given it away.*

Toll Booths

Permission, Apple, and saying no

131

*The web's founding gift was that nobody had to
approve you.*

Buy a domain, launch, let customers decide. Asking
permission to launch is an indignity even when permission is
granted.

132

*A platform becomes intolerable at the moment
it becomes unavoidable.*

The same terms are a nuisance while there are other doors
and a hostage situation once there aren't.

133

*It was never only about the thirty per cent. It was
about who owns the customer.*

Sell through an intermediary and refunds, discounts and
moving a subscription elsewhere stop being yours to decide.

134

*Sometimes the answer is no, said loudly, with a
willingness to burn the thing down.*

A volatile conviction to keep holstered, and to have available.
Ordinary decisions are made better by somebody who could
refuse.

135

*Somebody else paid a fortune so the rest of you
could have a rule. Know whose fight it was.*

Rights that arrive quietly usually cost one company years and
a great deal of money.

136

*Unreasonable principle is a business asset that
professional management cannot hold.*

No board approves the fight that only a founder is willing to
take.

137

*A toll booth is billions. A squandered
relationship with everyone who builds for you
costs more.*

The bill arrives later, as the absence of enthusiasm for
whatever you launch next.

138

*Great companies don't last forever, and almost
none survive being handed to caretakers twice.*

Taste and conviction don't transfer with the title. Logistics
do.

Good Intentions

Regulation, monopoly, and the monument

139

Go after the premier problem first.

Aiming an intervention at the corner of an industry that still works costs you the fix you actually needed.

140

You may dislike how something looks and still make it worse by touching it.

Good intentions are not a method. The remedy has to be judged on its own results.

141

A failure everyone acknowledges and nobody can repeal is a declaration of bankruptcy.

The inability to undo a bad rule matters more than the rule.

*Argue the other side for half a second, then
follow the merits.*

Ideological preference and daily use are allowed to disagree,
and the work should decide.

The Gift Exchange

Open source, and what a king may not do

143

*You are not a vendor. Nobody has a claim on
your time.*

Users of a gift can take it, use it, and contribute back. They
don't set the direction.

144

*Build what you need. You'll do a worse job
building what you imagine others need.*

Self-interest is the quality control: you can judge the thing
because you use it, so it gets built well and no larger than
required.

145

*There is no funding crisis. There is a confusion
about what kind of transaction this is.*

If you want to be paid for software, sell software, or take a job
that pays you to work in the open.

146

*Walking away is part of the arrangement, and
the receivers of gifts should say so more often.*

You owe maintenance exactly as long as you want to give it.
Gratitude, meanwhile, is nearly always undersupplied.

147

*You cannot hand out a gift and then send an
invoice years later.*

Released is released. Retroactive terms poison every project
anyone might build on.

148

*The licence is short on purpose, and the shortness
is the protection.*

Here's some software, no warranty, do what you want.
Anything longer starts inventing obligations.

149

*Those licences ended the war between
commercial and free software. Break them and
the peace goes with them.*

Clarity is what lets a company build on open foundations
without fearing a demand letter seven years in.

150

*Being aggrieved is fine. Acting on it from the
throne is not.*

Whoever heads an important project holds power, and the
discipline to leave it holstered is the job.

151

*Don't smell your own exhaust, and don't inhale
the haters either.*

Assess the work on your own scoreboard. Superfans distort it
as badly as detractors do.

BOOK EIGHT

The Life

Flow, danger, family, and the difference between the best things and the very expensive ones.

Mojito Island

Flow, retirement, and the top five per cent

152

There is no retirement for ambitious people. The beach lasts about two weeks.

Relaxation of that kind is its own hell for anyone whose satisfaction comes from making things.

153

Happiness is stretching just past what you can currently do.

Remove every problem from your plate and you don't get bliss. You get a flat line.

154

The sacrifice plan fails on all three branches.

Sell and you're bored in a fortnight. Fail and you've traded a decade for regret. Succeed and stay, and the work never gets easier anyway.

155

*You probably can't do it twice, and it wouldn't
feel the same if you could.*

Founders credit talent for what was partly a door being open
at the right moment. The first time is only available once.

156

Tell your younger self nothing.

Wisdom gets built one break at a time, and handing over the
results robs you of the experience that produced them.

157

*Responsibility is where meaning comes from,
and ignorance is what lets you accept it.*

Half the blessing at the start of anything hard is not knowing
how hard it will be.

158

*Stretch, but not for a decade. You don't get your
twenties back.*

A period of working too hard teaches what no advice can. A
decade of it charges rent you can't recover.

159

Ride two minutes slower and hear the birds.

The difference between all-out and nearly all-out is usually
smaller than the difference in what the journey cost you.

160

*Take the good bargain: top five per cent in
several things beats top tenth of a per cent in one.*

The last stretch of excellence costs a hundred times what the
first stretch did, and it demands everything else you own.

161

*To be the best in the world at one thing, you
must be obsessed. Most people don't need to be.*

Celebrate the obsessives and stop treating their bargain as the
only respectable one.

162

Go deep for weeks, then come up for air.

Uninterrupted tunnel vision produces alienation, whatever it
does for output.

CHAPTER 23

The Chair and the Bloodline

Family, and the scale that goes to a hundred

163

*Some of the most important decisions get made
by somebody who knows what they want while
you're still shrugging.*

The version of yourself who drifts past that fork is the one to
be afraid of.

164

*You thought the scale went to ten. It goes to a
hundred.*

Whole registers of experience stay invisible until you're inside
them, and the humbling is part of the value.

165

*Some truths cannot be transmitted in words,
only lived.*

Everyone says the same thing, it isn't a secret, and it still
doesn't transfer.

166

Trade all of it. Software, companies, race cars.

It sounds like a cliché, and the cliché is why people stop
believing it.

167

*You will marry the wrong person, on some
dimension. Plan for that rather than the
romantic ideal.*

Everyone available will fall short somewhere. Permanent
perfection is a poor premise for building a life.

168

*We removed institutions without knowing
which parts held the roof up.*

Some of the old rules were local superstition; some were
structural. Nobody can reliably say which is which.

169

*Matchmaking is the least solved problem we
have, and technology made it worse.*

Hiring is roughly solved, friendship isn't and is deteriorating,
and partnership is worst of all.

170

Children make the day honest.

A hard stop converts loose hours into real ones. If the day is
wasted, it's wasted, and you try again tomorrow.

171

*The eighty-hour week is mostly fluff wearing a
costume.*

An honest audit of where those hours go would embarrass
most of the people advertising them.

172

Thirty thousand years of ancestors to put you in that chair. Don't trade it for a few more emails.

Something has to be genuinely important to outrank the continuation of your own line, and almost nothing on your calendar qualifies.

173

Share the thing you already love with them, and it stops being a sacrifice.

Time with children is only a cost when the activity is chosen against your own grain.

The Edge of Adhesion

Speed, danger, and the guaranteed flow

174

*Programming gives you flow occasionally. A
race car gives it to you every single time.*

Flow at a keyboard is a lottery: the problem has to meet your
skill at the right angle. At speed, nothing is left over to
wander with.

175

*Drive at the edge of adhesion: a couple of per
cent of slip, and no more.*

The spectacular version looks fast and isn't. The quick way
sits one small movement from the wall.

176

*The stake has to be real, or it isn't the same
activity.*

Gambling was never about the poker. Remove the possibility
of losing and the attention goes with it.

177

*Load a program for every corner, then execute it
like a machine.*

Mastery here is repeatability, not inspiration, and the plan
still has to shift as the conditions decay.

178

*You can build a mental model precise enough to
run inches from something you cannot see.*

The sense arrives only with volume, and no amount of
explanation substitutes for the hours.

179

*Reaction time is the hardware, and it's
measurable.*

Ten milliseconds decides who leads into the first corner.
Some of the gap between people is simply not trainable.

180

*Sometimes the pass goes to whoever wants it
more, and both of you know it.*

Where skill is equal, the decision is made by whoever is
willing to risk more, and occasionally neither blinks.

181

*The professional's advantage isn't the peak. It's
the repetition.*

On a good day the amateur matches them. Doing it every
single time is what separates a hobby from a career.

182

The worst part of crashing is the team.

The repair bill is the smaller injury. Rare seasons where the
car, team and setup are all competitive are what actually got
destroyed.

*You cannot think about dying and still go fast,
and the danger is not theoretical.*

The thought makes speed impossible, so it isn't thought, and
the risk stays entirely real regardless.

CHAPTER 25

The Desk

Tools worth the hours you put into them

184

One large screen. Not several.

A mind that wants one thing in front of it is not served by
spreading the work across three.

185

*Sometimes you have to get properly annoyed
before you'll look at what else exists.*

Comfort inside one ecosystem quietly removes entire
categories of tool from your field of view.

186

*You touch these things all day. Spend
accordingly.*

The keys under your fingers for eight hours deserve more
thought than most people give a car they drive twice a week.

187

Latency changes how you use a computer.

A few hundred milliseconds of animation is enough to make
you abandon a feature you own.

188

*Encode the environment so a fresh machine is
perfect in half an hour.*

Not almost right with two hours of fiddling left. Perfect,
reproducibly, from a script.

189

*Learn to drive your environment from the
keyboard.*

A few days of cursing buys years of fluency. Start from a good
preset rather than building the whole editor yourself.

190

*A tool's benefits are worth nothing to somebody
whose workflow can't collect them.*

Judge the trade for your own practice. Most arguments about tooling are two people describing different jobs.

191

*If you use it because you think professionals
must, consider this your permission to stop.*

Nobody's tool needs to die. Adopting one out of obligation to an imagined standard is the error.

192

*Start with the language that has no ceremony,
add the one the platform requires, and reach for
the specialist only where it belongs.*

Three tools, chosen by job rather than by fashion, will cover most of a career on the web.

193

*Learn it by building something you want. You
can't download the language into your head.*

Reading a specification installs nothing. The mission drags
you through the parts that aren't fun.

194

*Reject the title engineer. Software writer fits
better.*

The engineering label flattens a rich field. Writers and
mathematicians describe the altitude people actually work at.

195

*The argument emerges while you write it. So
does the program.*

You know the shape of the problem, not the solution, and
the solution appears as you type.

196

*Trust the gut. It's a supercomputer you spent a
career building.*

People distrust instinct because they can't rationalise it to
others, which is mostly a fact about audiences.

197

Inspiration is perishable.

Draw up a detailed plan and the enthusiasm may be gone
before the plan is finished.

Second-Best Things

Money, empty calendars, and hope

198

*Everybody's number is double whatever they
have.*

The figure that would finally mean security moves with you,
forever, unless you notice the pattern and step off.

199

*Money removes a category of problems, installs
a fresh set, and leaves most of life untouched.*

Better to be rich than poor, and it isn't the wand people
imagine. Nobody has ever been argued out of believing
otherwise.

200

*The best things are free and the second-best are
very expensive. Keep the order straight.*

Enjoy the expensive things. Just don't confuse them for the
other kind.

201

An empty calendar is the reward.

A week with nothing scheduled is what the whole arrangement was for, and it takes years to stop feeling like something is missing.

202

Choose optimism, because you don't know either way.

Pessimism in advance costs you the present and buys nothing. Deal with the hardship when it arrives.

203

It's hard to tell in the moment which inventions were the disasters.

Verdicts formed during the event are frequently reversed, and the people best qualified to give them get plenty wrong.

*We hold both capacities. The work is cultivating
the better one.*

Generosity and cruelty, in everyone, all the time. Accept both
are in there and feed the half you'd want remembered.

Editor's Notes

Distilled from a conversation between David Heinemeier Hansson and Lex Fridman, recorded and published in July 2025. The positions are his; the compressions are the editor's. Where the two men disagreed, the disagreement has been kept.